

Managing Work Stress With CBT

Cognitive and behavioral tools for your wellbeing at work

4 psychology approaches · tips — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Cognitive and behavioral tools for your wellbeing at work

CBT (cognitive behavioral therapy) starts from a simple idea: it's not only situations that stress us, but above all our thoughts about them — and our behaviors.

This guide gives you concrete tools to spot and reframe your thoughts, adjust your behaviors, and regulate your stress at work.

Your intention

The work situation that stresses you most right now: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

How stress works

CBT model: Situation → Thoughts → Emotions → Behaviors. Facing the same situation, different thoughts lead to different emotions and reactions.

Acting on your thoughts and behaviors means acting on your stress.

Example

Facing a curt email from her boss, Sarah thought 'I'll be fired'; questioning the thought, her anxiety dropped.

My chain

For your situation: Situation → Thought → Emotion → Behavior. Write it.

The leverage point

Write: 'I can act on my thoughts and behaviors — not just endure.'

→ *It's my thoughts and behaviors that amplify or ease stress.*

Spot and reframe your thoughts

'I must be perfect', 'if I fail it's a catastrophe', 'I can't say no': these automatic thoughts and distortions (catastrophizing, perfectionism, all-or-nothing) amplify stress.

Spotting and nuancing them eases the pressure.

Example

Sure a mistake would be 'catastrophic', Karim tested it: the error was fixed in 10 min. His thought was exaggerating.

Thought journal

Note: automatic thought · distortion · more realistic thought.

Reframe

Turn an 'I must be perfect' into a fairer, achievable expectation.

→ *My automatic thoughts often exaggerate — I can nuance them.*

Acting differently

On behaviors: set limits, dare to say no, delegate, break tasks down, schedule breaks, gradually expose yourself to what you avoid (speaking up, asking for help).

Small behavior changes really reduce stress.

Example

By learning to say no to last-minute requests, Léa regained control — and less anxiety.

My key behavior

A behavior to change (say no, delegate, take breaks): _____

First small step

The smallest step you can take this week: _____

→ *Small behavior changes truly ease stress.*

Ease & prevent

Regulate your alarm system (breathing, relaxation, grounding) and tend to recovery: psychological detachment (truly switching off from work) prevents exhaustion. If stress becomes chronic or turns into burnout: consult.

Prevention beats cure.

Example

By switching off emails in the evening and taking real breaks, Marc saw his stress drop within weeks.

My recovery

How can you truly switch off from work (detachment) outside hours?

My calming

A regulation technique to try (breathing, relaxation, walking): _____

→ *Regulating and recovering prevents exhaustion.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- At work, it's often thoughts (perfectionism, catastrophizing, 'I must') that amplify stress.
- Spot and reframe your automatic thoughts (thought journal).
- Set limits, dare to say no, delegate (behavioral).
- Take real breaks and psychological detachment outside work.
- Breathing/relaxation regulates the alarm system.
- If stress becomes chronic or turns into burnout, consult (doctor, occupational psychologist).

To fill in

My thoughts

Automatic thought	More realistic thought

My behaviors

To change	First small step

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Map my situation-thought-emotion chain.

Week 2 — Reframe my automatic thoughts.

Week 3 — Change a behavior (limits, delegation).

Week 4 — Regulate & tend to my recovery.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The thought I reframe:
- The behavior I change:
- My recovery:

TO CLOSE

Your thoughts amplify or ease stress — CBT gives you back control.

CBT gives you back control over your stress.

This guide is a psychoeducation and coaching tool — not therapy or medical advice. If stress becomes chronic or turns into burnout, consult a doctor or an (occupational) psychologist. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.